The Road to the Other Side — Branching Narrative

This game is based on a true story that took place more than 20 years ago on the Russian-Ukrainian border.

1. Departure

DRIVER: The morning a man heads home from seasonal work is one of the happiest days of his life. And there's nothing I enjoy more than playing my part in somebody else's happiness.

But this morning was… Well… Something else.

PLAYER CHOICES

A. Get people moving

[Increases `killjoy` *by 1.]*

DRIVER: “One last cigarette, lads, then get your asses on the bus. If we don't get moving now, I'll have to drive through the whole damn night.”

B. Get people really moving

[Increases `threatening` *by 1.]*

DRIVER: “Move it, assholes. How long am I supposed to wait?”

C. Ask for a cigarette

[Increases `charisma` *by 1.]*

DRIVER: “Well? Anybody gonna spare their driver a cigarette? Where's that team spirit?”

2. The Body

DRIVER: “We’re missing one person. Ruslan isn’t with us,” I remember saying.

We found him in the site trailer. The reason for his absence became clear soon enough. Ruslan was simply… no longer with us.

But you don't abandon your own. Not even when things get bad. So, through the rearview mirror, I watched Ruslan's body resting against the window.

The solution was simple: pour vodka over Ruslan and pass him off as drunk at the border.

I was driving with murderous calm, knowing that getting Ruslan home is now my responsibility. I have to deliver him to his family so they can say goodbye and bury him properly.

Everyone was dead silent, but they weren't so calm a few hours ago.

DRIVER: “We're going to have to pay.”

IGOR: “Like there was ever a time we didn't.”

VITYA: “My wife'll make sure I end up keeping Ruslan company if I blow all our money on this.”

DRIVER: “The more we give them, the fewer questions they'll ask. And with a body in the vehicle, we want as few questions as possible.”

PLAYER CHOICES

A. Pool money from earnings into a bribe fund

[Increases `bank` *by 300,* `success` *by 1, and* `threatening` *by 1.]*

B. Contribute some money to a bribe fund and save the rest to help Ruslan's family with the funeral

[Increases `bank` *by 150,* `success` *by 2, and* `charisma` *by 1.]*

C. Refuse and bring all earnings to your own families

[Increases `killjoy` *by 1.]*

3. At the Border

DRIVER: We reached the border without trouble. I nervously tapped my fingers against the steering wheel, waiting for our turn.

IGOR: “Shit… We should've just left Ruslan there and reported it to the authorities. They would've handled it. This is all kinds of messed up.”

PLAYER CHOICES

A. This would take ages

[Increases `threatening` *by 1 and* `success` *by 1.]*

DRIVER: “You know how long they'd deal with it? We'd be stuck there for another week, easy. People have mouths to feed back home.”

IGOR: “We should've left him there and gone home to our families.”

DRIVER: “Then we'll leave you right here and see how you like it.”

B. He deserves a proper goodbye

[Increases `charisma` *by 1 and* `success` *by 2.]*

DRIVER: “Who knows when his family would've gotten him back, or what condition he'd have been in by then. Ruslan deserves a proper burial, not to be left in the hands of strangers.”

IGOR: “One week earlier, one week later…”

DRIVER: “Careful. We might bury you here first.”

C. Igor is right

[Increases `killjoy` *by 1.]*

DRIVER: “Maybe… Legally, that would've been the right thing to do. A lot less trouble for us, too.”

VITYA: “We're already at the border. No point talking about it now.”

4. The First Inspection

DRIVER: Finally, the line starts moving, and it's our turn. A round-faced, greasy-looking border guard appears at the lowered window and greets me with a cheerful smile. Behind him, another figure with a dog moves toward the trunk.

GUARD 1: “Good afternoon. Vehicle documents, please. And collect the passengers' passports. All Ukrainian citizens? Where are you coming from?”

DRIVER: “Returning from a work shift in Belgorod.”

The border guard gives an understanding grunt, then disappears from the window. Seconds later, the side door slides open, and he climbs into the cabin.

GUARD 1: “Stay seated. Passport inspection.”

DRIVER: The guys are nervous, but they answer steadily. I'm already beginning to relax when Ruslan's name is called.

Naturally, no one answers. Igor, sitting beside Ruslan, gestures toward him.

IGOR: “He's had too much to drink. Doesn't handle the road well,” he says in a hoarse voice, trying to sound casual.

DRIVER: The irritated guard shoves Ruslan's shoulder. His head lolls, and the guard grimaces.

GUARD 1: “What, did he shit himself or something?”

PLAYER CHOICES

A. Make up a story about Ruslan's connections

[Increases `threatening` by 1. The dialogue continues to the second inspection, where this choice contributes toward unlocking the option to invoke Ruslan's father's connections.]

B. Make up a tragic story

[Increases `charisma` by 1. The dialogue continues to the second inspection, where this choice contributes toward unlocking the option to tell the truth about Ruslan's death.]

C. Try to distract the border guard

[Increases `killjoy` by 1. The dialogue continues to the second inspection, where this choice contributes toward unlocking the option to say Ruslan got drunk and shat himself.]

D. Offer him money

[Available only if `bank >= 150`. Deducts 150 from `bank` and routes directly to the second inspection after the bribe dialogue.]

Branch A — Invoke his connections

DRIVER: “He could shit himself right there in the middle of the street, and nobody would lay a finger on him. His old man works for the Ministry.”

GUARD 1: The guard gave me a skeptical look. “And a government official's son goes to Russia to work construction? That's a new one.”

DRIVER: “Rich people's quirks. Maybe he doesn't take his father's money, but if somebody gives him a hard time, he knows exactly who to call.”

Branch B — Invent a tragic story

DRIVER: “His wife called him this morning. Apparently, she’s been cheating on him and wants a divorce. Poor bastard drank himself senseless over it. Told him he’d never see the kids again, too.”

GUARD 1: “Yeah… women can be real bitches. My first wife was the same way.”

Branch C — Distract the guard

DRIVER: “Come on, who's never shit themselves? Happened to me, too. Long drive, picking up guys like these, then some devil convinced me to stop for a cheburek.”

DRIVER: “An hour later I felt it - I was done for. Middle of the highway, nowhere to pull over, nowhere to…”

GUARD 1: “I get it. Shut up.”

Branch D — Offer a bribe

DRIVER: “He's always like this. We even took his money away, figured if he couldn't afford to drink, he'd finally sober up. Didn't help.”

DRIVER: “Truth is, he'll just drink it away when he gets home anyway. Maybe it'd be better if that money went to a good cause… or a good man.”

The guard gives me a knowing smirk. Before I even realize it, the bills have disappeared into his coat.

5. The Second Inspection

GUARD 2: “What are you waiting for?”

GUARD 1: “We've got one drunk here who won't wake up.”

DRIVER: I watch in horror as the second border guard grabs Ruslan and tries to shake him awake. His body nearly topples over.

GUARD 2: “Is he even alive?”

PLAYER CHOICES

A. Tell the truth

[Available only if `charisma >= 2`. Admits that Ruslan is dead, then routes to `the Aftermath`.]

DRIVER: “No, he's dead. We're transporting a body.”

The guards laughed, but they let us go.

B. Tell him about Ruslan’s father

[Available only if `threatening >= 2`. Routes to `the Aftermath` after the guards back off.]

DRIVER: I must have stayed silent for too long, because the others started telling them that Ruslan wasn't someone they wanted trouble with. Eventually, the guards backed off.

We drove on.

C. Say he got drunk and shat himself

[Available only if `killjoy >= 2`. Plays the cheburek story and routes to `the Aftermath`.]

DRIVER: I told them he'd gotten drunk and shit himself. It was the best I could come up with. Then I started telling them the cheburek story.

They didn't even let me finish. They just left.

D. Offer them money

[Available only if `bank >= 150`. Deducts another 150 from `bank` and routes to `the Aftermath`. The bank must still contain at least 150 after any bribe paid at the first inspection.]

DRIVER: I had no choice, slipped them a bribe. Luckily, we still had some money left.

E. Do nothing

[Always available. Leads directly to the arrest ending, regardless of the character variables or remaining bank balance.]

DRIVER: I couldn't think of a single thing to say. They locked us up, waited for the police, cuffed us, and took us away. That was the end of the road for us.

6. The Aftermath

The men around the bar murmur approvingly, clapping the driver on the back from all sides.

AUDIENCE: “And then? Did Ruslan make it home?”

PLAYER CHOICES

A. Sure thing

[Available only if `success >= 2`*. Leads to the best ending describing a successful return and proper funeral.]*

DRIVER: “You bet. Once we crossed the river at the border, we were back on our own ground. After that, nobody could touch us. Ruslan got a proper funeral a few days later.”

B. Not really

[Always available. Leads to the ending revealing that the patrol takes Ruslan's body away for examination.]

DRIVER: “Yeah… Just not the way we planned.”

“We got stuck in the river on the way back. No moving forward, no turning around. And wouldn't you know it, a patrol happened to pass by and stopped to help.”

“Helped, sure. Took Ruslan away and cut him open at the morgue to find out what killed him. After that… I don't know what happened.”